

THE NITISH WAVE The Bihar CM leaving after the conclusion of the winter session of the assembly in Patna, Nov. 10

ANI

> **"We have done this caste survey to have the social, educational and economic profile of our people. With the details we have, the government will make targeted interventions in terms of social welfare programmes to uplift the marginalised sections of Bihar society"**
>
> **NITISH KUMAR,** *Chief Minister, Bihar*

NDA ally Jitan Ram Manjhi for daring to question his government's caste survey, saying it was a foolish move on his part to have made Manjhi the chief minister in 2014.

More than anger, it's perhaps impatience that Nitish is feeling. It was he who led the initiative to get INDIA going, he who first announced that Bihar will hold a caste-based survey when the BJP-led central government said it had no intention of enumerating castes in the Census, and he who has delivered on the promise. Stealing a march over the BJP's women's reservation gambit, Nitish had announced the results of the caste survey only a fortnight later, on Gandhi Jayanti. And to demonstrate that he meant business, the Bihar CM on November 9 declared a 15 per cent enhancement of reservations for Scheduled Castes and Tribes (SC/STs), the Extremely Backward Classes (EBCs) and the Backward Classes (BCs), along with a slew of financial incentives for families earning less than Rs 6,000 a month. On November 21, the government notified the increase in reservations after governor Rajendra Arlekar gave his assent to the two bills.

There is no doubting the genie that Nitish has quietly unleashed while the two main national parties—the Congress and the BJP—are tied up with assembly elections in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Telangana. The move has the potential to rewrite the electoral narrative for the 2024 general election and project Nitish as the leading messiah of social justice. The BJP has already begun diluting its intransigence on the subject of a caste-based survey, with the states it rules saying they are not averse to the idea of the exercise within their jurisdictions, even as the Congress is pushing for a countrywide caste survey and proportional rights.

Is there more, though, to Nitish's move apart from its electoral cachet? To assess what Bihar's caste-based survey and the extra reservations and cash incentives mean—for Nitish, his state and national politics—one has to see what exactly has been promised, and to whom.

THE QUOTA GAMBIT

That Nitish wants to extract the maximum mileage out of his initiative is apparent. So, when he announced the results of the enumeration of the state's 215 castes on October 2, all that was revealed was how they stacked up numerically. So, EBCs and BCs were found to constitute 36 per cent and 27 per cent, respectively, adding up to 63 per cent of the state's population of 130 million instead of the 51 per cent assumed earlier. Which meant that the existing 27 per cent reservations for them in government jobs and educational institutions were grossly inadequate in proportion to their numerical strength. The announcement was greeted with criticism from the Opposition parties, which said that the numbers were manipulated to inflate the population of certain communities that favoured the ruling parties and underrepresented other castes like the Kushwahas. They also asked why the socio-economic status of the various castes had not been shared.

Nitish gave the answer to that criticism on November 9, when he got the Bihar assembly to unanimously pass two bills—the Bihar Reservation in Vacancies of Posts and Services Amendment Bill, 2023, and the Bihar Reservation (in educational institutions) Amendment Bill, 2023. Together, the twin legislations have taken reservations in government jobs and educational institutions to 65 per cent, breaching the 50 per cent limit set by